

SpaceX's Giant Starship V3 Just Flew to Space for the First Time!

From: Space.com Mined: 2026-05-23 3 min read

Have you ever watched a skyscraper fly? That's basically what happened on Friday when SpaceX launched its new Starship V3 a rocket as tall as a 40-story building! It was the first flight of this next-generation design, and even though not everything went perfectly, it was still a huge step toward someday sending people to the Moon and Mars.

Liftoff was at 6:30 p.m. from Texas, and the 408-foot-tall rocket roared into the sky on 33 engines. But right away, one engine on the booster shut down. Then, when the upper stage separated, it lost one of its six engines too. Still, the remaining engines pushed Starship all the way to space!

The plan was for the giant booster to gently splash down in the Gulf of Mexico, but a key **maneuver** failed, and it crashed instead. SpaceX had already cleared the area, so no one was hurt. The upper stage kept going and did something really cool: it opened a door like a PEZ candy dispenser and released 22 **satellites** 20 dummy ones and two real Starlink satellites with cameras.

Those cameras sent back stunning video of Starship floating in space. 'That is a Starship in space,' said a SpaceX commentator. The two camera-**satellites** even scanned the ship's **heat shield** tiles to check for damage before **reentry**.

SpaceX CEO Elon Musk called it 'an epic first Starship V3 launch & landing!' Even with the hiccups, this test proved the new design can reach orbit. Next time, they'll try to catch the booster with giant **mechanical arms** like a giant robot grabbing a falling skyscraper. How awesome is that?

Word Treasure

maneuver -- A tricky move that needs careful control.

satellites -- Machines sent into space to circle Earth and do jobs like taking photos or sending signals.

reentry -- The dangerous moment when a spacecraft comes back into Earth's atmosphere from space.

heat shield -- Special tiles that protect a spacecraft from burning up when it returns to Earth.

mechanical arms -- Giant robot grabbers that can catch a rocket booster in mid-air.

dummy -- Something not real, used just for practice or testing.

Background you need

SpaceX, founded by Elon Musk (a billionaire inventor), has been building bigger and bigger rockets to eventually take people to Mars.

The Starship is the largest rocket ever built -- taller than the Statue of Liberty -- and earlier versions sometimes crashed or exploded.

Every test flight, even with problems, teaches engineers how to make space travel safer and more reliable.

Break it down

WHO: SpaceX, the rocket company led by Elon Musk

WHAT: Successfully launched the giant Starship V3 into space for the first time, even though some engines failed and the booster crashed

WHERE: From a launch site in Texas, USA

WHY: To test the design and gather data for future Moon and Mars missions

Why it matters

Just like practicing for a big game, test flights like this help engineers learn how to make space travel safe enough for ordinary people -- maybe even kids like you one day.

Test what you remember

1. What was special about the Starship V3 launch?
 - (A) It landed on Mars
 - (B) It was the first flight of a next-generation Starship design
 - (C) It carried people to the Moon
 - (D) It was the smallest rocket ever launched
2. How many engines on the booster shut down right after liftoff?
 - (A) None
 - (B) One
 - (C) Three
 - (D) All 33
3. What did the upper stage do with the door that opened like a PEZ dispenser?
 - (A) Released 22 satellites
 - (B) Deployed a parachute
 - (C) Launched a smaller rocket
 - (D) Took a selfie in space
4. What happened to the booster during its landing attempt?
 - (A) It gently splashed down in the Gulf of Mexico
 - (B) It was caught by giant mechanical arms
 - (C) A key maneuver failed and it crashed
 - (D) It landed safely on a drone ship
5. What did the two real Starlink satellites do?
 - (A) They scanned the Moon for craters
 - (B) They took pictures of each other
 - (C) They scanned the heat shield tiles and sent back video
 - (D) They deployed more dummy satellites
6. How did SpaceX boss Elon Musk describe the test?
 - (A) A failure we can learn from
 - (B) A small but important step
 - (C) An epic first Starship V3 launch & landing!
 - (D) A boring routine test

Answer key (try the quiz first!): 1: B 2: B 3: A 4: C 5: C 6: C

Questions to think about

1. **Space enthusiast:** This launch proves Starship can reach orbit, a huge milestone! Even with hiccups, the design works and we're closer to Mars.
2. **Safety critic:** The booster crashed and engines failed. That's dangerous, and rushing tests could put future crews at risk.
3. **Engineer/teacher:** Every test teaches us something. Failure is part of learning, and SpaceX is using that to build a better, safer rocket.

MY THOUGHTS (at least 20 words):